

Supply Chain Coordination Supports Thriving Local Food Systems

Insights from a convening of producers and food supply chain stakeholders from the North Alabama local food system.

Shared Vision for the Future Agrifood System

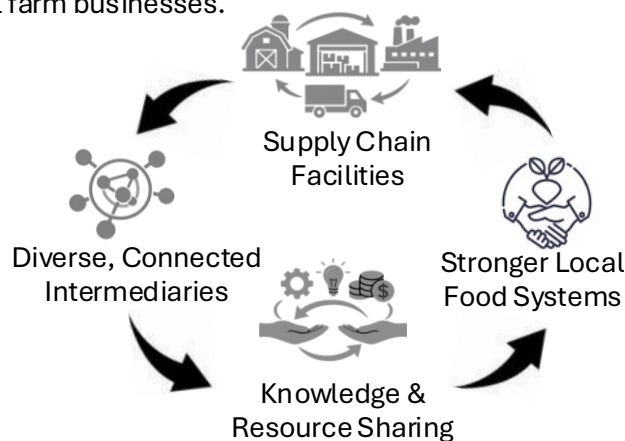
A thriving local agrifood system supported by coordinated efforts to connect producers and eaters/buyers to shared knowledge through a multitude of diverse intermediaries and provide opportunities to pool resources to scale individual farm businesses.

Why This Matters

Local food systems can improve:

- Rural economic resilience
- Food access and nutrition
- Regional supply chain stability
- Climate and environmental sustainability

Yet producers, supply chain intermediaries, and eaters/buyers **remain disconnected**, which results in **gaps in supply chain facilities and missed opportunities to cooperate**.



Key Barriers Identified



Lack of middle of the supply chain facilities

Gaps in food supply chain infrastructure (ex. cold storage, value-added processing, aggregation points) impact ability to scale.



Few resource providers for small farms

Agencies or resource providers lack knowledge about smaller-scale farm operations, resulting in missed opportunities for needed support.



Limited access to distant markets

Long distances to markets and gaps in middle supply chain infrastructure pose transportation and distribution challenges.



Limited access to information

Insufficient information for setting competitive prices, finding suitable markets and supporting coordinated marketing and transportation efforts.



Competitive rather than cooperative mindset

A shift from competitive to cooperative mindset is needed among local agrifood system actors to become a viable alternative to conventional food systems.

Community-Driven Solutions for Strengthening Local Food Systems

+ supporting agrifood system stakeholders

1. Diversify Local Food System Intermediaries

Incorporate more, diverse supply chain intermediaries to improve capacity for aggregation/distribution (e.g., food hubs), value-added processing (e.g., canning), and cold storage and/or kitchen capacity (e.g., churches, schools).



2. Strengthen Community Relationships

Build community relationships among producers, supply chain intermediaries, eaters/buyers to increase demand, enable more personal marketing opportunities, and leverage collective resources for scaling up.



3. Improved Information Systems

Adoption of innovative information systems to support local food price discovery, increase market visibility, and identify niche markets that conventional food systems do not cover.



4. Supply Chain Coordination

Regional engagement efforts to connect local agrifood system actors with smaller-scale production knowledge to surface needed supply chain investments, leverage existing opportunities, and uncover new opportunities.



5. Establish Local Food Councils

Food councils can coordinate infrastructure investments, policy support, and collaboration across food system actors.



6. Expand Research on Local Food Markets

More research is needed to identify barriers to local market growth, supply chain gaps, successful models from other regions, and opportunities for scaling local food demand.



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Workshop Information

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